



Stand up for the facts!

Our only agenda is to publish the truth so you can be an informed participant in democracy.
We need your help.

[More Info](#)

I would like to contribute

\$

[Join Now!](#)

Antisemitic claims about Brooklyn synagogue tunnel spread on social media

ISRAEL

NATIONAL

NEW YORK





By [Jeff Cercone](#)
January 12, 2024



By [Sofia Ahmed](#)
January 12, 2024

IF YOUR TIME IS SHORT

- A 60-foot tunnel was discovered under a building near the Chabad Lubavitch World Headquarters in Brooklyn, New York.
- When a cement truck came to fill in the unauthorized tunnel, young men trying to stop it clashed with police, leading to several arrests.
- There are no statements from authorities, credible news stories or criminal charges to signal the site was used for nefarious purposes, such as child sex trafficking or organ harvesting.

[See the sources for this story](#)

Amid spikes of social media antisemitism driven by the Israel-Hamas war, the discovery of a tunnel near a well-known Brooklyn synagogue spurred similar misinformation.

The tunnel first made news in December in a [local Crown Heights neighborhood media outlet](#). But the tunnel near the Chabad Lubavitch World Headquarters became a [national story](#) after police arrested a group of young worshippers who tried to prevent a cement truck from pouring concrete in the tunnel.

Social media claims about the tunnel and what it was being used for spread rampantly. Many posts claimed without evidence that it was used for child sex trafficking or organ harvesting.

The only charges pending in relation to the tunnel's discovery are for crimes such as reckless endangerment, criminal mischief and disorderly conduct, from when worshippers clashed with police. No one has been charged with child or adult sex trafficking, and authorities have made no public statements to say those crimes are suspected.

The Anti-Defamation League said the social media posts echo the [blood libel](#), an unfounded claim originating in the Middle Ages that Jewish people used the blood of non-Jews for rituals.

Here's what we know about the tunnel.



What happened?

Crownheights.info, a local New York news outlet, [reported Dec. 22](#) that a tunnel was found underneath a building near 770 Eastern Parkway, the site of the Chabad Lubavitch headquarters, home of the [global Hasidic Jewish movement](#) dating back 250 years.

On Dec. 24, the outlet posted an [Instagram video](#) it described as footage “leaked” from inside the tunnel. PolitiFact has not independently verified the video’s authenticity. It shows a tunnel and two rooms on floors above it. Authorities described the structure as a single, linear 60-foot-long underground tunnel, so the parts of the video’s footage that shows debris-filled rooms with doors is not from the tunnel.

The news made national headlines Jan. 8 when videos emerged of police clashing with protesters at the synagogue.

According to a Jan. 8 [X post](#) from Motti Seligson, a Chabad spokesperson, a group of “extremist students” some time ago broke through some walls in properties next to the synagogue to gain “unauthorized access.”

After a cement truck arrived to repair the damage, the people who damaged the property tried to stop the repair and vandalized the synagogue, he said.

[News reports](#) and [videos](#) show a chaotic [scene](#) of a group of young men clashing with police.

[News reports](#) said the men who secretly dug the tunnel did so because the late Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson had supported expanding the synagogue.

Ryan Degan, New York City Department of Buildings deputy press secretary, said the agency’s investigation found a single, linear 60-foot-long underground tunnel — 8 feet wide and 5 feet high — that was illegally excavated directly under a single-story rear extension behind 784 and 786 Eastern Parkway.

The extension connects four neighboring buildings, and is next to 770 Eastern Parkway. But the tunnel wasn’t connected to that building, he said. Degan said wall openings had been created in several areas of the adjacent buildings at the basement levels.

No other tunnels were found. Degan added that the tunnel threatened the stability of two other buildings.

“As a result of this extensive investigation, we have issued emergency work orders to stabilize the buildings above the tunnel, vacate orders in parts of the buildings to ensure occupant safety, and enforcement actions against the property owners for the illegal work,” Degan said.

Seligson wrote Jan. 10 [on X](#) that the space dug out by the men was “underneath a ground-level extension made by the synagogue decades ago.”

Baseless claims emerge



Claims that the tunnels were the site of nefarious behavior flooded social media. None is backed by statements from authorities, credible news stories or criminal charges.

The claims included:

- The tunnel was used for [child or adult sex trafficking](#) or as part of a pedophilia ring.
- [Baby carriages, highchairs and clothes](#) were found and sent for forensic investigation by police.
- Human [organs](#) were trafficked at the site.
- The tunnel was [connected to a children's museum](#). The Associated Press [reported](#) that the museum is across the street and not connected.

An Anti-Defamation League spokesperson said the incident sparked “hate-filled antisemitic conspiracy theories” with “absolutely no basis in fact.”

What the police said

The New York Police Department didn't respond to specific questions about what was found at the site. The department provided a statement that said officers responded Jan. 8 to calls of a disorderly group outside 770 Eastern Parkway.

The statement said officers were told a group of people entered the building by damaging a wall. Officers took 12 people into custody. No injuries were reported.

Police provided the names of nine men, ages 19 to 22, who have been charged in the incident. They face charges including reckless endangerment, criminal mischief and attempted hate crimes. Three others received summons for disorderly conduct.

What was found at the site

Many of the social media posts shared the [Dec. 24 video](#) from Crownheightsinfo.com. In it, the camera pans across a debris-filled room, then downstairs to another room filled with more debris.

Empty boxes, buckets and clothes can be seen in the footage. There's one item that some social media posts said was a highchair, but it's unclear that it is. The camera then passes through a hole in a brick wall and emerges in what looks like a dirt-filled tunnel.

“The tunnel was empty during our initial inspection on Tuesday morning aside from hand tools like shovels and light debris,” said Degan, when asked whether signs of illegal activity were discovered at the site.



New York Police Department spokesperson, emailed statement, Jan. 12, 2024

Ryan Degan, deputy press secretary for the New York City Department of Buildings, email interview, Jan. 12, 2024

Anti-Defamation League spokesperson, emailed statement, Jan. 12, 2024.

Rabbi Motti Seligson, X [post](#), Jan. 8, 2024

Rabbi Motti Seligson, X [post](#), Jan. 10, 2024

Chabad.org, [What Is Chabad?](#), accessed Jan. 12, 2024

The Associated Press, [Illegal tunnel under New York City synagogue destabilized nearby buildings, officials say](#), Jan. 11, 2024

The Associated Press, [A secret tunnel in a NYC synagogue leads to a brawl between police and worshippers](#), Jan. 10, 2024

The Associated Press, [FACT FOCUS: Discovery of a tunnel at a Chabad synagogue spurs false claims and conspiracy theories](#), Jan. 11, 2024

The New York Times, [60-Foot Tunnel Under Synagogue Left 2 Buildings Unstable, Officials Say](#), Jan. 10, 2024

The New York Times, [Secret Synagogue Tunnel Sets Off Altercation That Leads to 9 Arrests](#), Jan. 9, 2024

New York Post, [Inside the mysterious 50-foot-long tunnel beneath a Brooklyn synagogue that sparked a riot](#), Jan. 9, 2024

Fox News, [NYC rabbi horrified watching 'extremist students' who reportedly hired migrants to dig tunnel under synagogue](#), Jan. 12, 2024

Newsweek, [New York Synagogue Tunnel: What We Know, What We Don't](#), Jan. 11, 2024

Forward, [Arrests at Chabad's iconic headquarters after students thwart attempt to fill secret tunnel](#), Jan. 8, 2024

CrownHeights.info, [BREAKING: Tunnel Found Burrowed Under Women's Section of 770, Possibly Destabilizing The Building](#), Dec. 22, 2023

CrownHeights.info, Instagram [post](#), Dec. 24, 2023

[Instagram post \(archived\)](#), Jan. 10, 2024.

[Instagram post \(archived\)](#), Jan. 11, 2024.

[Facebook post \(archived\)](#), Jan. 9, 2024.

[Twitter post \(archived\)](#), Jan. 9, 2024.

[TikTok post \(archived\)](#), Jan. 11, 2024.

[Twitter post \(archived\)](#), Jan. 9, 2024.

Holocaust Encyclopedia, [Blood Libel](#), accessed Jan. 12, 2024.



**UNLOCKING
WORKING CAPITAL:
THE SUPPLY CHAIN
PAYMENTS PLAYBOOK**
A MASTERCARD BUSINESS PAYMENTS WEBINAR

[Register Now](#)



Sign Up For Our Weekly Newsletter

Enter your email

Sign Up

Browse the Truth-O-Meter

MORE BY JEFF CERCONE



TikTok Posts

stated on September 20, 2026 in a post:

President Joe Biden “cut off 440 reporters’ credentials.”



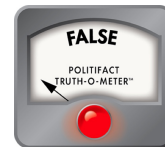
By Jeff Cercone • September 21, 2026



Social Media

stated on May 19, 2026 in in social

“San Diego mosque shoos couple.”



By Jeff Cercone • May 20, 2026



ANTISEMITIC CLAIMS ABOUT BROOKLYN SYNAGOGUE TUNNEL SPREAD ON SOCIAL MEDIA

Clear

Any Rating



Any Speaker

Any Category

Any Date Range



Markwayne Mullin

stated on October 1, 2026 in a speech at a rally in Oklahoma:

For President Donald Trump, “there’s no financial gain like the past presidents have had. It’s cost him to be in office.”



By Louis Jacobson • October 5, 2026



Donald Trump

stated on October 4, 2026 in a Truth Social post:

Brazil’s quick election results are proof that places like Detroit, Philadelphia and California “take weeks to rig” their elections.



By Amy Sherman • October 5, 2026



Donald Trump

stated on September 21, 2026 in an X post:

Roy Cooper was “in New York speaking at a New York Times ‘Climate Forward’ event” when Hurricane “Helene slammed into North Carolina.”



By Paul Specht • October 5, 2026



WinSenate

stated on September 25, 2026 in an ad:

Iowa Republican Senate candidate Rep. Ashley Hinson voted against releasing the Jeffrey Epstein files.



By Loreben Tuquero • October 2, 2026



Donald Trump

stated on October 1, 2026 in a Truth Social post:

“I stated, numerous times, that it would take 4-6 weeks to get rid of THE IRAN NUCLEAR THREAT, and I did it in one night!”



By Amy Sherman, Maria Briceño • October 2, 2026



TikTok Posts

stated on September 28, 2026 in a post:

These videos show scenes of alleged sexual assault at Cornell University.



By Jeff Cercone • October 1, 2026



Byron Donalds

stated on September 28, 2026 in an ad:

“Just months after” the 2010 Deepwater Horizon oil spill, David Jolly “was in Washington, pressuring Congress to expand drilling off the Florida coast, over \$5 million in billings.”



By Samantha Putterman • October 1, 2026



Senate Leadership Fund

stated on September 16, 2026 in an ad:



Sherrod Brown supports “forcing childhood sex change surgery.”



By Louis Jacobson • October 1, 2026



John E. Sununu

stated on September 8, 2026 in his primary night victory speech:

“Chris Pappas voted to raise taxes 68 times. Every tax vote he’s made was to raise taxes.”



By Louis Jacobson • October 1, 2026



Mike Rogers

stated on September 24, 2026 in a TV interview:

Abdul El-Sayed “could not condemn the terrorist who tried to attack and kill 140 Jewish children right here in Michigan.”



By Caleb McCullough • October 1, 2026



Ashley Hinson

stated on September 2, 2026 in a social media post:

Iowa Democratic U.S. Senate candidate Josh Turek “skipped 58% of the votes at the Statehouse this year.”



By Anna Mitchell • September 30, 2026





Mike Rogers

stated on September 23, 2026 in an X post:

“Abdul El-Sayed supports defunding the police and emptying prisons.”



By Caleb McCullough • September 28, 2026



WinSenate

stated on September 24, 2026 in an ad:

Sen. Susan Collins “voted to cover up the Epstein files” and Jeffrey Epstein’s “business partner funneled \$3 million” to a Collins super PAC.



By Amy Sherman • September 28, 2026



Rob Sand

stated on August 24, 2026 in an ad:

Iowa once had “the best public schools in the country,” but is now “in the bottom half.”



By Grace Olson • September 24, 2026



Republican National Committee

stated on September 2, 2026 in an X post:

“54% of North Carolina commercial driver’s licenses were issued illegally to foreign nationals.”



By Paul Specht • September 24, 2026





Texas PAC

stated on September 11, 2026 in an ad :

Democratic U.S. Senate candidate James Talarico “supported using taxpayer dollars for sex change surgeries on young children.”



By Ben Brasch • September 24, 2026



Chris Pappas

stated on September 15, 2026 in a press release:

New Hampshire Republican U.S. Senate candidate John Sununu “led efforts to privatize Social Security.”



By Louis Jacobson • September 23, 2026



Sherrod Brown

stated on September 3, 2026 in a campaign ad:

Sen. Jon Husted “led the push to bring data centers to Ohio and gave billions of tax dollars to make it happen.”



By Cami Henry-Seymore • September 23, 2026



Donald Trump

stated on September 22, 2026 in a speech to the United Nations General Assembly:

The people who warned of climate change, the “Russia hoax” and the “Ukraine hoax” are the same people “now saying that AI is going to kill us all.”





TikTok Posts

stated on September 20, 2026 in a post:

President Joe Biden “cut off 440 reporters’ credentials.”



By Jeff Cercone • September 21, 2026

Load More

OFFICES

District of Columbia

1800 I Street NW
Washington, DC 20006

Florida

801 3rd St.
S St. Petersburg, FL 33701
727-821-9494

PEOPLE

Donald Trump

JD Vance

Mitch McConnell

Mike Johnson

Joe Biden

STATE EDITIONS

California

Florida

Iowa

Michigan

New Hampshire

New York

North Carolina

Pennsylvania

Texas

West Virginia

Wisconsin

ABOUT US

Our Process

Our Staff

En Español

Who pays for PolitiFact?

Advertise with Us

Corrections and Updates

Newsletters

RSS FEEDS

Recent Articles and Fact-checks

Recent Fact-checks

Suggest a Fact-check

FOLLOW US



THE FACTS NEWSLETTER

Enter your email

Sign Up

[Terms & Conditions](#) [Privacy Policy](#) [Copyright](#)

©All Rights Reserved Poynter Institute 2020, a 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization

POLITIFACT | Poynter.

